

Jarod Govers

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Personal Summary

Fortitude, focus and fervour; these are the three foundations that form the backbone for my work ethic and experience, alongside my research and academic success. My passion is in exploring new technologies, particularly chatbots and GenAI, in the field of Human-Computer Interaction – leveraging my background in AI and cyber-security. The flexibility of my multi-faculty studies and employment background drives my desire to work in collaborative research and development roles.

My PhD investigates strategies, qualities and risks of using conversational generative AI to address online polarisation and develop responsible AI. These GenAI approaches include proactive measures such as online conflict mediators, anthropomorphic online chatbots, and AI-for-teams. These concepts aim to reduce online divisions without impacting free speech or resorting to ambulance-at-the-bottom-of-the-cliff reactive measures by addressing the grievances that result in an escalating online conflict.

Professional Skills

- Designing and conducting human-interaction studies with chatbots and interactive games
 - Including online interactive studies and in-person codesign workshops with industry
- Social and technical policy writing and analysis (technical briefing papers, papers, public policy)
- Machine Learning and Data Mining competency (PyTorch, Keras, TensorFlow, Weka)
- Competency in Python, C#, C/C++, Java, Scala, Android Development, R, Git, GitLab
- Networking and cyber-security knowledge (reverse engineering, penetration testing)
- Database design, SQL and NoSQL programming (Oracle, SQL Server, MongoDB)

Behavioural Skills

- Entrepreneurial and innovative
- Team-oriented and passionate
- Organised, strong attention to detail
- Confident and effective communicator

Education History

PhD in Human Computer Interaction at the University of Melbourne (2023-ongoing, 2nd year).

Master of Cyber Security at the University of Waikato (2021-22) **GPA 9.0/9.0** [A+ on every course].

Bachelor of Science (Technology) at the University of Waikato – **GPA 9.0/9.0** [A+ on every course].

Publications (as First Author Only, excl. those under-review):

Feeds of Distrust: Investigating How AI-Powered News Chatbots Shape User Trust and Perceptions

- Published in ACM Transactions in Intelligent Systems (2025).
- Investigated the potential and risks of biased news chatbots in manipulating public opinion, where our results identified that the interactive agency afforded to by chatbots leads users makes users more susceptible to bias and political indoctrination than the static online print news media.
<https://dl.acm.org/doi/10.1145/3722227>

AI-Driven Mediation Strategies for Audience Depolarisation in Online Debates

- Published in the premier ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems (CHI) 2024
- Developed psychology-driven mediation chatbots to reduce polarisation in online debates.
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3613904.3642322>

Down the Rabbit Hole: Detecting Online Extremism, Radicalisation, and Politicised Hate Speech

- Published in the Association of Computing Machinery (ACM) Computing Surveys Journal (CSUR).

- Investigated the state-of-the-art Natural Language Processing, non-textual community detection (graph/network) models, and visual image-detection approaches to Extremism, Radicalisation and Hate speech (ERH) detection in a social and computational framework – coined as ERH Context Mining.
<https://doi.org/10.1145/3583067>

Prompt-GAN – Customisable Hate Speech and Extremist Datasets via Radicalised Neural Language Models

- ACM-published ICCAI 2023 conference – <https://doi.org/10.1145/3594315.3594366>
- Involved generating synthetic hate speech posts and tweets using a Generative Adversarial Networks built on language transformers. Setting a record in hate speech detection.

Employment History

June 2025-Sept 2025 Research Intern at Nokia Bell Labs (Cambridge UK):

Designed and ran fifteen collaborative codesign workshops with industry and researchers to develop AI tools to help development teams design and brainstorm responsible AI (particularly to help teams design AI in a way that ensures ethical and legal compliance with the EU AI Act). Output study under-review.

June 2023-Present Sessional Tutor and Demonstrator for the University of Melbourne (Part-time)

For holding tutorials and sessions for Foundations in Computing, and Fundamentals of Interaction Design.

Aug 2022-Feb 2023 Infrastructure Support Engineer for Fonterra (Full-time)

Role involved proactive design and maintenance, alongside on-demand support for systems, security, and network architectures for servers and virtualised environments.

Feb 2022-Aug 2022 Graduate Assistant for the University of Waikato (Part-time)

Head tutor of the COMPX553 'Extremely Parallel Programming' post-graduate course. Required organisational planning and communication skills enhanced by my experience as a lab assistant.

Mar 2020-Feb 2022 Lab Assistant for the University of Waikato (Part-time)

Employed to tutor and mark students' laboratory work for six Computer Science courses.

Nov 2020-Feb 2021 Junior Design Engineer (Critical Communications Performance Monitoring Internship)

Involved metadata analysis of Tait Digital Modular Radio Base Stations, Siemens Gateways and Tait Nodes for automated performance monitoring and reporting of critical communication infrastructure.

Awards and Achievements

2024:

- Best Presentation Award – 10th CIS Doctoral Colloquium at the University of Melbourne.

2023:

- University of Melbourne Ingenium Scholarship.

2022:

- Attained highest-possible GPA across both Bachelor's and Master's (with First Class Honours).

2021:

- APEC 2021 Voices of the Future Delegation – representing NZ youth on behalf of the University of Waikato in cyber-diplomacy for the NZ-hosted Asia-Pacific Economic Cooperation 2021 summit.
- University of Waikato Research Masters Scholarship – based on prior academic achievement.

2020:

- Lewis Fretz Prize in International Relations.
- Golden Key Academic Honors Society Membership Offer.

2019:

- University of Waikato Dean's Award for Excellence.

Volunteering/Contributions

2025:

- Session chair for CHI25 'Decision Making with AI'.
- Student Volunteer for HRI25' (ACM/IEEE International Conference on Human-Robot Interaction).

- Associate Chair (1AC) for CHI25' Late Breaking Work Committee.
- Reviewer for DIS25, CSCW25, CHI26.

2023/24:

- Student Volunteer for CHI24' (ACM Conference on Human Factors in Computing Systems).
- Reviewer for CHI24', CHI25' and ICWSM24', ICWSM25' (AAAI Conference on Web and Social Media).
- Student Volunteer for Melbourne Computing and Information Systems Doctoral Colloquium.

2019-2022:

- University of Waikato Academic Board, Divisional, and Class Representative.

2015-2022:

- Delegate and volunteer for the United Nations Youth New Zealand.

2015-2019:

- New Zealand Cadet Forces – No. 10 Sqd. Air Training Corps.

Interests

I have a passion for emerging technologies such as Virtual Reality and flight simulation, as well as music, games and anime. My spark to be inquisitive extends into global issues, particularly cyber and international security, which are also favourite pastimes as I strive to keep in the loop. I love to bring people together, as I have a passion for talking to people as much as my studies makes me talk to computers all day.
